

Witchcraft Paper

HIST-103 | The Emergence of Modern Europe

Instructor: Dr. Lindsay O'Neill

Term: Fall 2026

Assignment Summary

Grade weight: 20%
Start date: 2025-11-06
Due date: 2025-11-10
Group project: No
Notes: Submit via your TA's Brightspace by 11:59pm. Do not search the Internet.

Overview

This 4 page paper will ask you to read a number of primary sources detailing early modern witchcraft trials and to pick a prompt to make argument about what you read. You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace.

Due Date & Submission

- Due Nov 10 at 11:59pm via your TA's Brightspace page
- Witchcraft Paper Due (Nov 10)

Required Readings

- Brian Levack, The Witchcraft Sourcebook, Chaps 36-44, 46-47 (assigned for section Nov 6)
- Pick ONE of the following prompts and use Brian Levack's The Witchcraft Sourcebook (2015) for your evidence

Format Requirements

- 4 pages, double spaced
- Well written, include a specific thesis that gives a roadmap to your paper
- Body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence
- At least two quotes or few specific examples that back up your main idea
- See the tips below and the paper rubric for more guidance
- In the paper you can ONLY cite Levack's book or lecture

Prompts (pick ONE)

- Based on what you read in the Levack primary sources: What are witches accused of attacking or harming? What does this say about what people valued at the time?

- Using what you read in the Levack primary sources consider this: According to their confessions, what appears to tempt people to turn to the devil or witchcraft and what does it say about society at the time?
- Using the Levack primary sources, examine the gender breakdown between the accused and the accusers. Are male witches treated the same or differently? Are the accusers mostly male or female? Why? What does this all tell us about gender and/or community during this period?
- Using the Levack primary sources, what do these trials tell us about who had power in these societies or how class played a role in the trials and accusations? Do the trials show state power or communal power?

Restrictions

- Do not search the Internet. We want you to just use Levack and maybe lecture for this paper.
- If you include other sources without checking with your TA you will be penalized.
- We reserve the right to tweak the prompts and guidelines up to a week before the assignment is due

Helpful Hints

- Include direct quotes and/or specific examples from the primary sources and cite them
- Your evidence should come from the primary sources, not the abstracts from the beginning
- Each body paragraph should have its own distinct topic, centered on an idea rather than being descriptive
- The best paper should reach for what those points together tell us about society at that time
- In-text citations are fine: For example (Levack, 12)

Full Syllabus Extract

Witchcraft Paper - 20%

This 4 page paper will ask you to read a number of primary sources detailing early modern witchcraft trials and to pick a prompt to make argument about what you read. You will turn it in via your TA's Brightspace. See Brightspace for prompts.

Witchcraft & Daily Life Paper

Due Nov 10 at 11:59pm via your Tas Brightspace page

Paper: 4pgs, double spaced, should be well written, include a specific thesis that gives a roadmap to your paper, the body paragraphs should start with a topic sentence that says exactly what your main idea for the paragraph is and has at least two quotes or few specific examples that back up your main idea.